MANOJ DHAKA

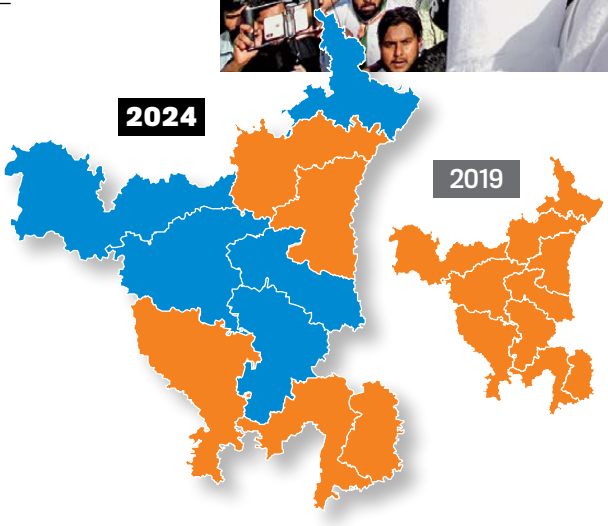


▲ **BHUPINDER SINGH HOODA**
*Leader of Opposition, Haryana*

# HOODA IS BACK IN THE GAME

**Reducing the BJP's perfect 10 tally of 2019 to a 5-5 stalemate, the Congress sets the stage for an intense finale in the assembly polls later this year**

*By* **Anilesh S. Mahajan**




**TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 10**

| | BJP | CONG |
|---|---|---|
| 2024 | 5 (46.1%) | 5 (43.7%) |
| 2019 | 10 (58%) | 0 (28.4%) |

*Vote share in ( )*

**IN a wake-up call for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)**, coming just months ahead of the assembly election in Haryana, its Lok Sabha tally in the state has dropped from a perfect 10 to just five. And, what's more, the saffron party's vote share has plummeted to 46.1 per cent from the 58 per cent it cornered in 2019, also falling short of the combined numbers of the Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)—47.6 per cent—who took on the saffron juggernaut as part of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA).

Much of the credit for the Congress's resurgence and the ruling BJP's plight goes to former chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, who has also consolidated his position as a pre-eminent Jat leader in the state. Through deft political manoeuvring, Hooda not only discredited intra-community rivals like the Chautalas—all candidates fielded by the Abhay Chautala-led Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) and his nephew Dushyant-led Jannayak Janta Party (JJP) ended up losing their deposits—but also engineered the return of his cousin and former Union minister Birendra Singh from the BJP besides attracting Independent Jat legislators. Also, it was he who insisted on joining hands with the AAP to prevent any split in votes. As an icing on the cake, his son Deepender wrested the family bastion Rohtak from the BJP with a huge 345,000-plus margin.

Hooda's strategy revolved around exploiting Jat disillusionment with the BJP—stemming from the perceived sidelining of their interests, even as the community comprises 22 per cent of the state's electorate. It all started with the BJP's decision to appoint a non-Jat chief minister, Manohar Lal Khattar, in 2014, and was exacerbated by the 2016 quota agitation besides the farmers' and wrestlers' protests. The Congress's success in sweeping all four seats in Jat-dominated areas—Hisar, Rohtak, Sirsa and Sonepat—underscores Hooda's firm grip on the community's vote. Bolstering this advantage was the party's ability to chip away at the BJP's support among the Dalits and Sikhs.

But the BJP is not a lost cause either. The party has cultivated a robust voter base among non-Jat Other Backward Classes (OBCs), comprising 21 per cent of the electorate, as well as Rajputs, Baniyas, Punjabis and other forward castes, which enabled it to retain five seats. As the state gears up for the assembly polls scheduled for October, the BJP will have to further strengthen its rainbow coalition of castes to counter Hooda's dominance. Meanwhile, the Congress is riding high on the momentum of its Lok Sabha performance and will be itching to dislodge the Nayab Singh Saini-led BJP regime when the time comes. ■